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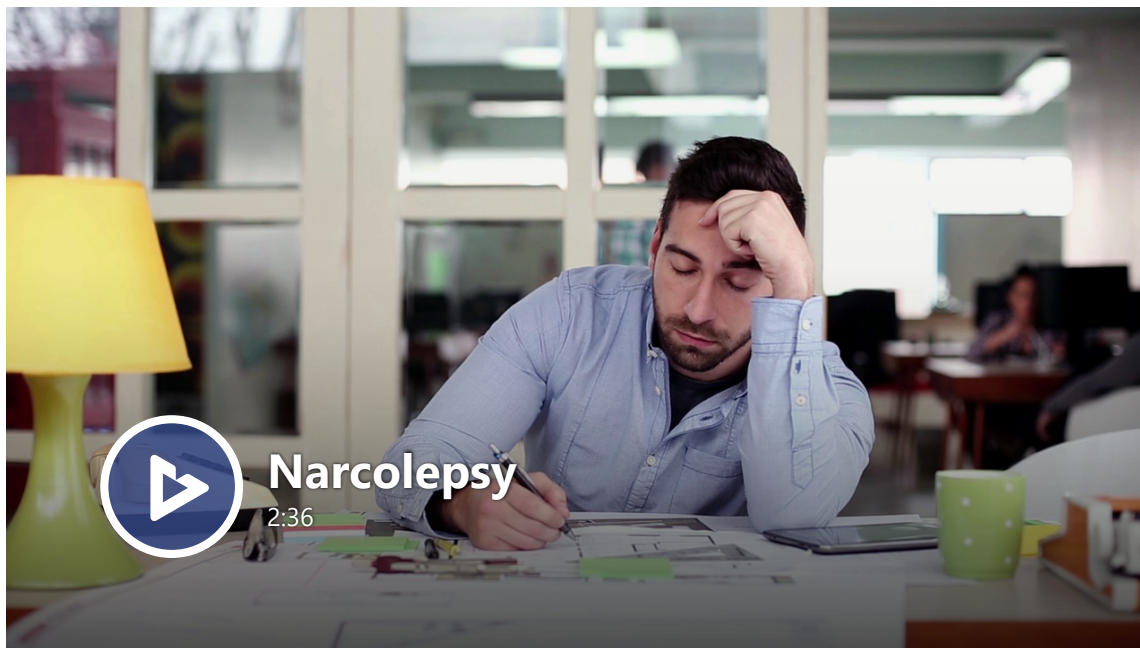
Narcolepsy

What is narcolepsy?

Narcolepsy is a sleep disorder. It's a lifelong disease of the central nervous system.

Narcolepsy causes excessive and overwhelming daytime sleepiness, even after getting plenty of nighttime sleep. If you have narcolepsy, you are likely to become drowsy or to fall asleep at inappropriate times and places. These sleep attacks may happen with or without warning.

You may have repeated attacks in a single day. The drowsiness may last a long time. Nighttime sleep may be split up, and you may wake up often.



Narcolepsy

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What causes narcolepsy?

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The cause of narcolepsy is not known. But it's usually related to abnormally low levels of hypocretin in the brain. Hypocretin is a chemical that regulates the sleep/wake cycle. Exactly why some people have low hypocretin levels and narcolepsy isn't known. Narcolepsy can also be related to genetic factors, inflammatory disorders, and tumors.

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What are the symptoms of narcolepsy?

These are the most common symptoms of narcolepsy. But symptoms may differ a bit in each person. Symptoms may include:

Excessive daytime sleepiness. This is an overwhelming desire to sleep at inappropriate times.

Cataplexy. This is a sudden loss of muscle control ranging from slight weakness to total collapse. It most often occurs during times of strong emotion.

Sleep paralysis. This is being unable to talk or move for about a minute when falling asleep or waking up.

Hypnagogic hallucinations. These are vivid and often scary dreams and sounds reported when falling asleep.

Disrupted sleep.

Other symptoms include:

Automatic behavior. This is doing routine tasks without conscious awareness of doing so, and often without memory of it.

Waking up often.

You may have other problems as you cope with this condition. These include:

Feelings of intense fatigue and continual lack of energy.

Depression.

Trouble concentrating and memorizing.



Vision (focusing) problems.

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Eating binges.

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Trouble handling alcohol.

Your health care provider will ask about your health history and do a physical exam. Lab tests to confirm diagnosis and plan treatment may include:

Overnight polysomnogram. A sleep specialist will monitor you during an entire night of sleep.

Multiple sleep latency test. This test is done during the day, after a full night's sleep. It measures when you fall asleep and how quickly rapid eye movement (REM) sleep occurs.

The goal of treatment of narcolepsy is to help you remain as alert as possible during the day. It's also important to reduce times when you lose muscle control. Ideally, this can be done using a minimal amount of medicine.

Medicines. Central nervous system stimulants are usually prescribed for extra sleepiness. Antidepressants may help with muscle control. Sodium oxybate is a medicine that may improve sleepiness and cataplexy.

Nap therapy. Having 2 or 3 short naps during the day may help control sleepiness and maintain alertness.

Healthy diet.

Regular exercise. Exercising every day for at least 20 minutes and at least 4 to 5 hours before bed. This improves sleep quality and helps people maintain a healthy weight.

Behavioral therapy.

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A number of lifestyle changes may help manage narcolepsy. Some of these include:



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Sticking to the same sleep schedule 7 days a week. This can help you sleep better.

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Next steps

Here are some tips to help you get the most from a visit to your health care provider.

Know the reason for your visit and what you want to happen.

Before your visit, write down questions you want answered.

Bring someone with you to help you ask questions and remember what your provider tells you.

At the visit, write down the name of a new diagnosis and any new medicines, treatments, or tests. Also write down any new instructions your provider gives you.

Know why a new medicine or treatment is prescribed and how it will help you. Also know what the side effects are.

Ask if your condition can be treated in other ways.

Know why a test or procedure is recommended and what the results could mean.

Know what to expect if you do not take the medicine or have the test or procedure.

If you have a follow-up appointment, write down the date, time, and purpose for that visit.

Know how you can contact your health care provider if you have questions, especially after office hours or on weekends.

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